

businesses can be leveraged in almost all the new businesses that the group has entered,” says Rajiv Memani, Chairman and CEO of professional services firm EY India. He points to the group’s distribution might in cement and how that works well for paints. The group has entered sectors driven by value creation, like in jewellery—with the launch of Indriya in 2024—which has a natural affinity to retail, where the customer profile is more towards the upper end.

For a group that was historically known for a big play in the commodities sector, the shift to customer-facing businesses was not just strategic but also in line with a changing India. That was kicked off with the acquisition of Madura Garments in late 1999 for ₹236 crore, marking the entry into fashion retail. In one swoop, Louis Philippe, Van Heusen, Allen Solly, Peter England came into the fold. Since then, it has extended the portfolio to include ethnic wear by investing in domestic brands such as Sabyasachi, Shantanu & Nikhil, House of Masaba and Jaypore.

“An ambitious revenue target of \$25 billion has been set for the consumer businesses and that is 25% of the group turnover over the next five years. By comparison, this segment clocked revenues of \$13 billion in 2023-24,” says Rajiv Agarwal, Professor (Strategy, Entrepreneurship & Family Business) and Department Chair (Strategy), SP Jain Institute of Management & Research, Mumbai.

CONSTANT EVOLUTION

Hemendra Kothari, veteran investment banker and Chairman of DSP Investment Managers, who has known Birla for decades, describes him as “successful and focussed.”

Birla was thrust into a leader-



Birla’s ability to think long term, backed by strong execution, has ensured his group continues to grow